



Roots

The faces were pale. No food was cooked in the house. It was the sixth day of the forced holiday from school for children who were making life miserable for the adults in the house – the same childish tiffs, wrangles, noise and somersaults as though the fifteenth of August had not come at all. The wretched urchins did not realize that the English had left and, while leaving, had inflicted such a deadly wound that it would fester for years to come. India was operated upon by such clumsy hands and blunt knives that thousands of arteries were left open. Rivers of blood flowed, and no one had the strength left to stitch the wounds.

Had it been a normal day, the little devils would have been sent outdoors. But for the last couple of days the atmosphere had become so foul that the Muslims of the city were virtually living under siege. The houses were padlocked, and the police patrolled outside. So the children were free to let loose their terror inside the house. Of course, the Civil Lines was quiet as usual. In any case, filth spreads where there is a surfeit of children, poverty and ignorance – preying grounds for religious fanaticism, the seeds of which had already been sown. On top of it, the swelling number of refugees from Punjab created panic among the minority Muslim community. The garbage dump was being raked, and the filth had come on to the road.

There were open skirmishes at two places. However, in the state of Marwar, Hindus and Muslims had much in common and could not be distinguished from one another by their names, features or attire. Those Muslims who came from outside Marwar could be identified easily: they had

already crossed the border to Pakistan when they got wind of what was to happen on the fifteenth of August. As far as the old inhabitants of the state were concerned, they had neither the sense nor the status for anyone to talk to them about the complicated India–Pakistan problem. Those who had any sense, understood the situation and had prepared for their security. Among the rest were those who were tempted to go to Pakistan by the rumours that four seers of wheat cost only one rupee there and a cubit-long naan only four annas. They were returning as they realized that to buy four seers of wheat, they needed one rupee and though a cubit-long naan cost a quarter, it still had to be paid for. And those rupees and coins were neither sold nor did they grow in fields. To acquire them was as difficult as was the struggle for existence.

So a serious problem arose when it was openly decided to throw out members of the minority community. The Thakurs told the officer in clear terms: ‘Look, the people are so intermingled that, for combing Muslims out, you need staff, which involves wasteful expense. However, if you want to buy a plot of land for the refugees, that can be arranged. Only animals live in the forest, and they can be driven away any moment.’

Only a few select families remained – they were mostly in the employ of the Maharaja, and there was no question of their leaving. There were also those who were packing their bags and preparing to leave. Ours was one such family. Till Barré Bhai returned from Ajmer, there was no urgency. But as soon as he returned, he tried to create panic, yet no one paid heed. As a matter of fact, no one would have taken him seriously if Chabban Mian – may Allah grant him prosperity – had not played a trick. Having tried in vain to persuade his family to emigrate to Pakistan, Barré Bhai had almost given up when Chabban Mian decided to inscribe ‘Pakistan Zindabad’ on the school wall. Roopchandji’s children were up in arms and wrote ‘Akhand Hindustan’. This led to a fight, to intimidation and death threats. As the matter got out of hand, the police were called in, and the few Muslim children on the spot were put into a lorry and sent home.

Now behold! When these children reached home their mothers, who were always too ready to curse them invoking cholera and plague on their head, ran out of their houses solicitously and held them to their bosom. In normal circumstances, if Chabba had come home after a fight with Roopchandji’s children, Dulhan Bhabi would have served him a few resounding slaps and sent him to Roopchandji for administering a castor oil and quinine mixture.

Roopchandji was not only our family doctor but was Abba's longstanding friend as well. His sons were my brothers' friends and his daughters-in-law were friends of my sisters-in-law. This close friendship extended to the children. The two families were so close to each other over three generations that no one had the slightest suspicion that the country's partition would rupture their relationship.

There were, of course, members of the Muslim League, the Congress and the Hindu Mahasabha in both families, who held fierce debates on religious and political matters. But it was more like a football or a cricket match. If Abba was a Congresswala, Doctor Saheb and Barré Bhai were supporters of the League. Gyan Chand was a Mahasabhai while Manjhle Bhai was a communist and Gulab Chand a socialist. Women and children supported the party patronized by their husband or father. When an argument ensued, it was usually the Congress supporters who tipped the scales. Abuses were hurled at the socialists and the communists, but they would both end up siding with the Congress. That would leave the League and the Mahasabha to act in unison. They were each other's enemy but invariably got together to attack the Congress.

However, over the last couple of years, there was a ground-swell of support for both the League and the Mahasabha. The Congress was in disarray. The entire new crop of the family, with the exception of one or two impartial Congressmen, spruced themselves up like the National Guards under the command of Barré Bhai. On the other side, a small group of Sevak Sangh was raised under Gyan Chand's leadership. But this did not strain mutual affection and friendship.

'My Lallu will marry none but Munni,' the Mahasabhai Gyan Chand would tell Munni's father, the Leaguer. 'We'll bring gold anklets for her.'

'Yaar, I hope they won't simply be gold-plated.' Barré Bhai would have a dig at Gyan Chand's trade.

If the National Guards wrote 'Pakistan Zindabad' on the walls, the party of Sevak Sangh would wipe it out and write 'Akhand Hindustan'. This was the time when the formation of Pakistan was still a matter of jokes and jibes.

Abba and Roopchandji would listen to all this and smile. They would make plans for a United Asia.

Untouched by politics, Amma and Chachi would talk of spices like coriander and turmeric and their daughters' dowries. The daughters-in-law were busy aping each other's fashions. Besides salt, pepper, etc., medicines

also came from Doctor Saheb's place. If one sneezed, one ran there. If anyone fell sick, Amma would make rotis thick with pulses, and dahi vadas. An invitation would be sent to Doctor Saheb, who would arrive holding the hands of his grandsons.

His wife would say, 'Don't eat there, do you hear?'

'And how would I collect my fees, then? Listen, send Lala and Chunni as well.'

'Hai Ram, you've no shame,' Chachi would mutter.

It was great fun when Amma fell sick. 'No, I'll not allow this joker to treat me,' she would say. But who would go to call in a doctor from the city when there was one at home. Doctor Saheb would come as soon as he heard of Amma's illness.

He'd tease, 'If you gobble up all pulao-zarda, how can you avoid falling ill?' Amma would retort from behind the purdah, 'Everyone's not like you.'

'Well, why make excuses? If you want to see me, just send word, and I'll be here. You need not fake illness!' he'd say with a mischievous smile. Amma would jerk her hand back in mock anger and mutter curses. Abba would smile indulgently.

If Doctor Saheb came to see a patient, everyone else would line up for a check-up. If one had stomach problems, another a pimple; others had either an inflammation of the ear or a swollen nose.

'What a nuisance, Deputy Saheb! I'll give poison to one or two. Do you take me for a vet that you pounce on me like a pack of animals?' Doctor Saheb would go on muttering while examining them.

Whenever he came to know that a new baby was expected, he would explode: 'Hunh! The doctor's for free. Procreate as many times as you want, and make my life miserable!'

But as soon as the labour pain started, he would pace restlessly between our veranda and his. He caused panic with his screams and shouts, rendering it difficult for the neighbours to come. The would-be father would be slapped vigorously and castigated for his foolhardiness.

But as soon as the newborn's cry reached his ears, he would leap from the veranda to the door and then into the room, followed by Abba in a state of nervousness. The women would resent and curse them and then go behind the purdah. He would examine the pulse of the mother and pat her back. 'Good show, my lioness.' Then he would cut the umbilical cord and bathe the baby. Abba would nervously act as a clumsy nurse to him. Then Amma would start

screaming, 'God's curse! These men have no business to be here.' Under the circumstances, both would slink away like two chastised children.

When Abba was paralysed, Roopchandji had retired and his medical practice was restricted to his own house and ours. Abba was being treated by some other doctors, but Roopchandji would keep constant vigil along with Amma and the nurses ... After Abba's passing away, he felt a new sense of responsibility besides the affection he had towards the members of our family. He would go to the children's school to get the fees waived, prevent Gyan Chand from charging on the girls' dowry. In the house, nothing was done without consulting him. So much so that when it was suggested that two rooms be added to the western wing of the house, the plan was scrapped at Doctor Saheb's instance.

'Why don't you build two rooms upstairs, instead,' he suggested, and it was acted upon. Fajjan was not ready to opt for science in F.A.; Doctor Saheb thrashed him with his shoes, and the issue was resolved. When Farida fought with her husband and returned home, her husband sought Doctor Saheb's help. As Sheela entered his family as the wife of his younger son, the problem of having to hunt for a midwife was solved. She would run from the hospital as soon as word was sent. Forget about charging a fee, she'd present the baby with a cap and a kurta on the sixth day.

But today, when Chabba returned after the fight, he was fêted as a crusader, a mard-i-ghazi having won a battle. Everyone asked him about his daring acts. Only Amma was mute, as she had been from the fifteenth of August when the tricolour was hoisted on the roof of Doctor Saheb's house and the Muslim League flag on ours. Between these two flags there was a chasm miles wide. Amma would look at its bottomless depth with her melancholy eyes and shudder. Then, like a deluge, refugees began to arrive. As the relatives of the eldest daughter-in-law arrived from Bhawalpur having lost all their possessions and somehow escaping with their lives, the chasm widened. And then, when the in-laws of Nirmala arrived from Bhawalpur in a half-dead state, the chasm became filled with venom-spewing snakes.

When Choti Bhabhi sent word that her son had a stomach ailment, Sheela Bhabhi drove the servant away. No one made any comment. Neither did anyone speak about one's ailment in the house. Barri Bhabhi forgot her fits of hysteria and began to pack up her belongings in haste.

'Don't touch my trunk.' Amma at last broke her silence. Everyone was stunned.

'Aren't you coming with us?' Barré Bhai asked sharply.

'No. Do you think I'll go to die among those Sindhis? God's curse on them! They wander about in flowing burkhas and pyjamas.'

'Why doesn't she go to the younger son in Dhaka?'

'Aye, why should she go to Dhaka? Those headhunting Bengalis knead rice in their hands and then slurp it down,' taunted Mumani Bi, Sanjhle Bhai's mother-in-law.

'Then go and stay with Farida at Rawalpindi,' Khala suggested.

'Tauba! May Allah save us from the Punjabis. They speak like the denizens of hell.' My taciturn Amma was rather voluble that day.

'Aye, Bua, you're acting like a woman who would rather sit in the wilderness than seek shelter in anyone's house. Aye, Bi, stop throwing tantrums as though the emperor has invited you, sending his elephants and black horses to pick you up ...' In spite of the grim atmosphere, peals of laughter rang out. Amma's face fell further.

'Stop behaving like children,' Sardar Ali, the leader of the National Guards reprimanded.

'You're talking nonsense. Do you want us to stay back and get killed?'

'You all go. As for me, where shall I go at this age?'

'At the end, do you want your ruin at the hands of these kafirs?'

Khala Bi kept count of her luggage. Along with gold and silver, she also stuffed bone powder, dry fenugreek and Multani mitti in bundles. She was taking them along with such care as though the sterling reserves in Pakistani banks would fall without them. Getting angry, Barré Bhai threw away these bundles three times, but she screamed so loudly it was as if Pakistan would become poor without this 'wealth'. Eventually one had to take out the cotton from the mattresses soaked with children's urine and pack them in bundles. Utensils were stuffed into gunny bags, beds dismantled and their legs tied together with rope. Right before our eyes the well-equipped house slowly turned into misshapen bundles and boxes.

Now the luggage seemed to have grown legs and danced through the house.

Amma's trunk, however, rested immobile.

'If you have decided to die here, no one can stop you,' Bhai Saheb said finally. And my simple, innocent-looking Amma stared at the sky with her wandering eyes as though asking herself, 'Who could kill me? When?'

'Amma has become senile. She's not all there,' Manjhle Bhai whispered.

‘What does she know how the kafirs have tortured innocents! At least life and property will be safe if we have a land of our own.’

If my taciturn Amma had had a sharp tongue, she would have retorted: ‘What’s this strange bird called “our land”? Tell me where’s that land? This is the place where one was born, one grew up in body and mind. If this cannot be one’s own land, then how can the place where one simply goes and settles down for a couple of days be one’s own? And who knows whether one won’t be driven out from there as well and be told “Go and inhabit a new land”? I am like a lamp in its last gasp. A mild gust of wind and all this fuss about choosing a land will be over. After all, this game of one’s land vanishing, and inhabiting a new land, is not very interesting. There was a time when the Mughals left their country to inhabit a new country. And today you want to establish a new one. As though the land is no better than a pair of shoes – if it gets a little tight, throw it away and get a new one.’ But she was silent, and her face looked more weary than before, as though she, after her quest for a land over centuries, was exhausted. And she seemed to have lost herself in that quest.

Time passed on, but Amma stayed steadfast in her position like a banyan tree that stands upright through storms and blizzards. But when the caravan consisting of her sons and daughters, sons-in-law, daughters-in-law and grandchildren passed through the big gate and got on to the lorries under police supervision, her heart fluttered. Her restless eyes gazed helplessly towards the other side of the chasm. The house on the other side seemed as far removed as a fleeting cloud in the distant sky. The veranda of Roopchandji’s house was desolate. Once or twice when the children came out, they were dragged in quickly. But Amma’s tearful eyes caught glimpses of those eyes behind the door and chiks, eyes that were brimming over with tears.

When the lorries left kicking up a lot of dust, some dead soul on the left side seemed to take a breather. The door opened and Roopchandji emerged with heavy steps and gazed at the vacant house like a thief. For some time he tried to trace the images of those who had left in the dust haze. Failing, his gaze wandered for a while in the desolation and got fixed to the ground.

Having surrendered all the assets of her life to the mercy of God, Amma stood in the desolate courtyard. Her heart sank, and she got scared like a small child, as though ghosts would pounce on her from all sides. She felt giddy and supported herself against a pillar. As she turned to the room in

front, her heart came to her mouth. It was here that the ghunghat was lifted from the moon-like face of the young and timorous bride who had surrendered her life to her husband. In the room on the other side, her eldest daughter had been born, whose memory pierced through her heart like lightning. There, in the corner, her umbilical cord was buried ... In fact, all her children had their umbilical cords buried there. Ten images of flesh and blood – ten human beings were born in that hallowed room from the sacred womb which they left behind that day. They had left her hung in thorns like an old snake-slough and made good their escape. In search of peace and contentment, looking for the place where wheat was sold for four seers a rupee. The voices of her children filled the room. She ran towards it with outstretched arms, but her lap was empty. The lap that newly wedded brides touched for luck, so that their wombs would not remain barren. The room lay desolate, and she returned, terror-stricken.

However, she could not stop the flight of her imagination. Tottering, she ran to another room, the one where her life-partner had breathed his last after fifty years of married life. Wrapped in the shroud, his body had been laid near the door. The whole family had stood around it. He was fortunate to have passed away, lamented by his dear ones. But he left me behind, I who lie here today like an enshrouded corpse, uncared for. Her legs gave way, and she slumped at the spot where the head of her dead husband had rested and where she had been lighting lamps with trembling hands for the last ten years. But there was no oil in the lamp that day, and the wick had burnt out.

Roopchandji was pacing up and down his veranda. He was cursing everyone – his wife, children, the government and the silent street that stretched before him – also the bricks and stones, the knives and daggers. Indeed, the whole universe seemed to be afraid and cringe before his torrent of curses. His special target was the vacant house that stood across the road and seemed to taunt him as though he had broken it, brick by brick, with his own hands. He was wrenching out the things that were deeply entrenched in his very existence, like roots, but felt as though his flesh would come off his body with them. Eventually, he gave up the effort with a groan, and his curses stopped abruptly. He stopped pacing, got into the car and sped away.

As night descended and the street corner became desolate, Roopchandji's wife entered our house stealthily through the back door holding two trays of food. The two old women sat across from each other silently. They were mute, but the eyes communicated everything. The food trays remained

untouched. When two women indulge in backbiting, their tongues run like scissors; but when they are overwhelmed with emotion, their lips get sealed.

Alone in the house, Amma was oppressed by painful thoughts throughout the night. 'I hope they won't be done away with on the way. Nowadays, whole trainloads of people are being slaughtered' – so ran her thoughts. She had nursed the crop with her heart's blood through fifty years, and that day it had been exiled from its own land to find a new land. 'Who knows whether the new soil will be conducive to these saplings or make them wilt. These poor saplings! Choti Bahu – may Allah protect her – her baby is due any moment. Who knows in which wilderness she will deliver it. They left everything – their homestead, job, business. Have the vultures left anything for them in the new land? Or will they have to return soon? When they return, will they get the opportunity to develop their roots again? Who knows whether this old skeleton of mine will be a witness to the return of spring?'

She kept on muttering to herself for hours, clutching the walls and parapets of the house. Then she slumped on the floor. There was no question of sleep amidst the nightmare in which she saw the mutilated corpse of her youthful daughter, her young daughter-in-law being paraded naked and the grandchildren being cut to pieces. Perhaps she had dozed off for a moment or two when she heard a great commotion at the door. One may not care for one's life, but even a lamp whose oil has run out shudders before its final gasp. 'Is natural death less terrifying that it should come in the form of men who have turned into demons? People say that they catch even old women by their locks and drag them along the street so violently that their skins come off revealing the bones. And then, the horrors of the world are let loose in such a manner that the horrors of hell pale into insignificance!'

The pounding on the door became more violent. Malik-ul-Maut, the angel of death, seemed to be in a hurry. The lights came on. A voice came from afar, as though from the bottom of a well. Perhaps the eldest son was calling out. No, it seemed like the voice of the younger ones from some hidden corner of the other world.

So everyone has reached the new land? So fast? She could clearly see the younger son and the youngest standing along with their wives and children. Then, all of a sudden, the whole house came back to life. The souls came alive and stood around the grieving mother. The hands of the old and the young touched her tenderly. Soft smiles spread on her dry lips.

Apprehensions swirled and vanished in the overwhelming tumult of happiness.

As she opened her eyes, she felt the touch of familiar fingers on her pulse. 'Sorry, Bhabi, if you want to see me, just send word, and I'll be here. You need not fake illness!' Roopchandji said from behind the curtain. 'Bhabi, today I must be paid my fees. Look, I have brought back your good-for-nothing children from Loni junction. Scoundrels! They were running away. They were not ready to trust even the police superintendent.'

Again a smile blossomed forth on the old lips. She sat up. There was silence for a while. Then two pearls of warm tears trickled down and fell on Roopchandji's wrinkled hands.